



DOGS **AT** WORK

Dogs do not know they have jobs. They follow scent, movement, instinct, training and reward. The “work” begins when humans turn those natural abilities into value: safer airports, faster searches, healthier people, protected livestock, better science. Dogs are an invisible workforce whose contribution is felt emotionally but rarely counted economically.



TO THE DOG; IT'S A GAME.

Working dogs do not know they have jobs. To a sheepdog, moving livestock is instinct, training and the best game in the world. To a detection dog, finding the scent is a puzzle with a reward at the end. To a medical alert dog, noticing that their human smells wrong is not a shift pattern. It is just what they do.



TO HUMANS, IT'S A JOB.

It only becomes work when humans benefit from it. This series looks at the dogs that help Britain function — the noses at the border, the paws on the hills, the search dogs in the woods, the assistance dogs beside their people, and the bio-detection dogs helping scientists ask whether disease has a smell.



THE PAYMENT; VERY DIFFERENT

They are paid in food, shelter, praise, tennis balls, head strokes and the occasional stolen sausage. But their value is measured in time, safety, independence, science and trust. This is about that hidden workforce, and the question behind every wagging tail: if dogs give us this much, what do we owe them back?



LEARN ABOUT...

MEDICAL

BIO-DETECTION DOGS

THE DOGS TEACHING MEDICINE HOW TO SMELL DISEASE

In 2025, two dogs called Bumper and Peanut sniffed out Parkinson's disease in a double-blind trial with up to 98% specificity. They are not replacing doctors. They may be doing something stranger: proving disease has a smell, so the machines of the future know what to look for. The dog doesn't become the machine. The dog invents it.

BUMPER AND PEANUT



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WHY **DOGS** Love DOING

Dogs seem happiest when they have something to do.

For thousands of years they have been selected to chase, retrieve, guard, herd, track, dig, carry and solve problems alongside people, so many of those behaviours are deeply rewarding in their own right. A Labrador fetching a ball, a Collie rounding up the family, or a Terrier digging furiously under a hedge may look like play to us, but to the dog they are using the same instincts, senses and problem-solving skills their ancestors relied on for real jobs.

“Work” does not need to mean employment: anything that gives a dog a purpose, a challenge and the chance to use the abilities it was built for can provide the satisfaction of a job well done.

WHY **we** Love DOGS DOING

For thousands of years, their enthusiasm has made our lives easier.

They herd animals we could never control alone, find people we cannot see, retrieve things we cannot reach, guard homes and livestock, guide people through the world and use extraordinary noses to detect drugs, explosives, disease and even signs of some cancers. What looks like a dog happily following its instincts can save humans hours of work, enormous effort and sometimes lives.

Perhaps that is the remarkable bargain at the heart of our relationship with dogs: the jobs we desperately need doing are often the very things they absolutely love to do.



LEARN **ABOUT...**

MEDICAL

MEDICAL ALERT DOGS

THE COLLEAGUE WHO NEVER CLOCKS OFF

A medical alert dog learns one person so completely it can warn them their own body is about to go wrong — often before they know themselves. That's not a pet. That's a colleague. Even if the only wages are dinner and the occasional stolen sausage.

BRAMBLE





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WHAT WE **owe** DOGS

Far more than affection. For centuries they have guarded our homes, protected livestock, carried messages, found the lost, hunted food, controlled vermin, pulled loads, guided people, served in war and rescue, and taken on countless jobs simply because working beside us became part of their lives.

What we owe them is responsible care, patience, safety, companionship and the chance to use the instincts and abilities we deliberately bred into them.

After everything dogs have done for us, the least we can do is make sure their lives are not only useful to humans, but good for them too.

WHAT DOGS **often** Get

They get food, shelter, protection, veterinary care, companionship and a place inside our families. Many live warm, comfortable lives filled with walks, play, affection and jobs chosen for enjoyment rather than survival.

But dogs have not always received a fair return and that is still the case in modern times for some dogs. The same animals bred to work beside us can be neglected, abandoned or treated as just tools, or status symbols and disposable possessions.

Some spend their lives bored and under-stimulated, while others are pushed into jobs or environments that damage their welfare.



LEARN **ABOUT...**

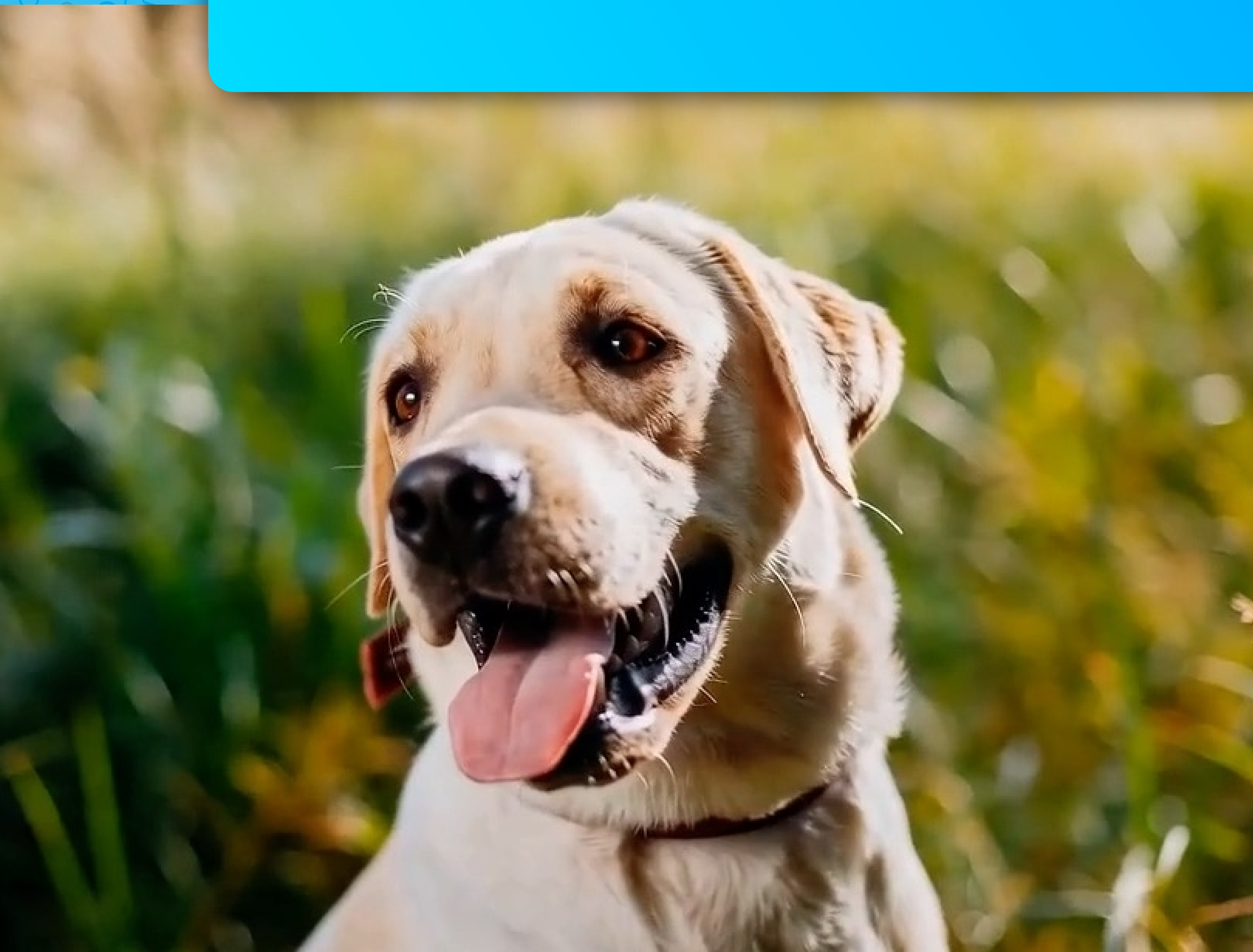
MEDICAL

BIO-DETECTION DOGS

THE MACHINE THAT MAY OWE DOGS A BISCUIT

In Milton Keynes, scientists are building an electronic nose to sniff out prostate cancer — trained on data the dogs gathered first. The dog wrote the manual for its own replacement, and it could not care less. It just wants its biscuit. This is the last piece of the medical trilogy.

MEDICAL DETECTION DOGS





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WORKING DOGS **DO NOT** **KNOW** THEY HAVE JOBS

- To a **sheepdog**, moving livestock is instinct, training and the best game in the world.
- To a **detection dog**, finding the scent is a puzzle and an instinct with a reward at the end.
- To a **medical alert dog**, noticing that their human smells wrong is not a shift pattern.

Results in:

- Search dogs in the woods finding lost people
- The bio-detection dogs helping identify diseased by smell

It is just what they do.

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coming soon

RURAL

SNIFFING DOGS

POLICE FORCE DOGS

Tracking, searching, and the noses that screen a border before anyone opens a suitcase.

coming soon

EMERGENCY

HEADERING DOGS

WATER-LEAK DETECTION DOGS

Yes, really — dogs that sniff out leaks in the water network. Almost nobody knows they exist.

coming soon

EMERGENCY

RESCUE DOGS

SEARCH & RESCUE DOGS

Air-scenting and trailing dogs that find missing people when time is running out.

coming soon

PEOPLE

INDEPENDENCE DOGS

seeing eye DOGS

The clearest economic case of all: a life lived independently, measured in more than sentiment.

coming soon

RURAL

HEADERING DOGS

SHEEPDOGS

One of the oldest and most economically important dog jobs in Britain — a farm worker with four legs.

coming soon

SCIENCE

DETECTION DOGS

CONSERVATION DETECTION DOGS

Finding newts, invasive species and tree disease that humans simply cannot see.